Small Engine Repair Vocational Training Lab (Barn Upgrade)

Bama Works (Winter/Spring 2026)

Autism Sanctuary, Inc.

Jason Brewster
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Application Form

Organization Information

Project Name*

Name of Project.

Small Engine Repair Vocational Training Lab (Barn Upgrade)

Organization Mission*

Please briefly explain your organization's primary mission and the work you do in Central Virginia.

Autism Sanctuary's mission is to enhance the lives of those with autism through nature-based activities by fostering community connections and providing personalized support.

Requested Amount - Lower Limit*

The Community Foundation understands that each organization has unique funding needs. To ensure we can best support your work with the foundation's limited resources, please provide a funding range that aligns with the work of your organization. Please consider factors such as project scope, duration, anticipated outcomes, and funds from other sources when determining this range.

$7,000.00

Requested Amount - Upper Limit*

Maximum award = $10,000.

$10,000.00

Primary use of funds*

Please categorize your request based on the primary use of funds.

Facility Improvements

Project Sector*

If you are seeking funding for a specific project/program, please select the description that most closely aligns with that project/program. This might be the same as your organization as a whole or it might be different.

Mental Health and Substance Abuse

Project-specific geography*

Please select the locale you are primarily serving with the work described in this application. (You can select multiple items)

City of Charlottesville

Albemarle County
Fluvanna County
Greene County
Louisa County
Nelson County

Project-specific demographics served*

Please briefly describe the demographics of the population that you are primarily engaging in the work described in this application.

We primarily serve adults (ages 18+) with developmental disabilities, specifically Autism Spectrum Disorder, residing in Charlottesville and Albemarle County. This population faces a national unemployment rate exceeding 85%. Financially, 100% of our participants are Medicaid Waiver recipients, meaning they are low-income with assets strictly restricted to under $2,000. We actively partner with Region Ten CSB to recruit from underserved neighborhoods, ensuring racial and economic diversity within our cohorts. Our program specifically targets individuals with high support needs who are often excluded from traditional vocational training, providing the specialized, sensory-friendly environment they require to build marketable skills and achieve economic independence.

Rural Serving*

Is your organization located in and/or primarily engaging a rural community?
Rural areas are considered any area in our region outside the City of Charlottesville and the urban ring of Albemarle County.

Yes

Organization Leadership*

Is the organization primarily engaging and/or led by people of color? Please select all that apply.

Led by (Executive Director [or equivalent] is a person of color)

Organization History*

How long has your organization been in operation?

6 - 10 years

Staff Size*

0.5 - 6 Full-Time Equivalent Positions

Annual operating budget size*

Roughly what will your annual expenses be this year?

$250k – $499k

First Time Applicant?*

Is this your group/organization/project's first time applying for funding from the Charlottesville Area Community Foundation?

No

Site Visit Contact Information
NEW IN 2026 In an effort to manage staff capacity, the foundation will perform site visits for most, but not all, applicants. Organizations can always request a site visit.

Site Visit Contact Information*
First Name

Jonathan

Site Visit Contact Information*
Last Name

Dixon

Site Visit Phone Number*
571-408-5641

Site Visit Email*
jonathan@autismsanctuary.org

Fiscal Sponsorship*
Is your organization fiscally sponsored? Fiscally sponsored organizations do not have EIN/Tax IDs.

No

Address Verification

Confirm Mailing Address
Has your mailing address changed recently? If you wish to confirm your mailing address, select 'organization history' above. Please note: this will take you out of this application. You will have to return to the application by selecting 'apply' and then 'continue application'.

No

Returning Applicant

Returning Applicant*
Did you receive this grant in the past calendar year?

No

Issues & Actions

Brief Application Summary*

Please summarize your funding request in 2-3 clear and concise sentences.
Note: This summary will be used by the Foundation staff and the Review Committee to conduct the initial review of your proposal. This summary may also be used to share funding requests with our fundholders.

Example: "Funding request of $10,000 to support the Paradigm Explosion program. The program will enhance the educational and extracurricular offerings for rural high school students. The aim of the program is to level the playing field for students in rural high schools."

Autism Sanctuary requests $10,000 to renovate a barn into a Small Engine Repair Vocational Lab. Building on our Fall 2024 agricultural grant, this funds a concrete floor and lifts to create a safe, year-round facility where adults with autism learn marketable mechanical trade skills.

Identification of the issue(s)*

What current trends, needs, or challenges are you seeing in the community that your program/organization will address?
Please use local data and/or observations to illustrate.
There are many ways to gather evidence and data takes many forms such as: stories, statistics, surveys, focus groups, journal entries, debriefing sessions, case studies, logs, registries, interviews, etc.

We address two critical issues: the severe unemployment "cliff" for adults with autism and the lack of accessible vocational infrastructure in Albemarle County. Nationally, 85% of autistic adults are underemployed. While our Fall 2024 Bama Works grant successfully launched our agricultural employment track, we have identified a subset of participants who possess strong mechanical aptitude but struggle with agricultural tasks. They require a different vocational pathway.

Currently, our ability to provide this mechanical training is physically limited. Our "shop" is a 600-sq-ft barn with a dirt floor, poor drainage, and no ventilation. It creates immediate safety hazards: tools rust, uneven ground makes using appropriate tools unsafe, and engines cannot be run indoors due to exhaust fumes. This limits training to fair-weather days and prevents the use of professional-grade diagnostic equipment.

Furthermore, there is a regional environmental issue of "disposable equipment." Without affordable repair options, Albemarle County residents landfill repairable mowers. By not having a functional shop, we miss the opportunity to train our participants in the "circular economy." This project bridges the gap between a population eager to learn technical trades and the physical facility required to teach them safely.

Use of Funds*

How will you use these grant funds to address the problem or support the work you described?
Please include a brief budget narrative if seeking funding for a specific program.
Tip: Think about describing the "who, what, when, where, and how" of your actions.

The $10,000 grant will fund the "hard costs" of transforming our storage shed into a professional Small Engine Repair Lab. This capital improvement leverages the success of our previous agricultural grant by creating the capacity to maintain our own fleet.

- Foundation & Flooring ($6,000): We will pour a reinforced concrete slab over the existing dirt floor. This is critical for safety. It allows for the use of rolling tool chests, provides a stable base for hydraulic lifts, and creates a barrier against ground moisture that currently damages expensive parts. It also ensures accessibility for participants with mobility challenges who cannot navigate uneven dirt.

- Safety & Ventilation ($1,500): We will install a high-CFM exhaust fan and ventilation hood. This allows students to safely run and test combustion engines indoors year-round without risk of carbon monoxide exposure, transforming a seasonal program into a full-time vocation.

- Equipment Infrastructure ($2,500): Funds will purchase a small rotary lift (for zero-turn mowers) and a heavy-duty workbench system. The lift is an essential accommodation, raising equipment to eye level so participants can work without physical strain.

This project uses Bama Works funds to build the permanent "shell," while our Medicaid operational budget funds the instructors and daily activities.

Total Project Budget (if applicable)

$25,000.00

Total Organization Budget*

What are your anticipated current fiscal year total organizational expenses?

$285,000.00

Project/fund use start date*

06/01/2026

Project/fund use end date*

10/31/2026

Note: The Community Foundation will not fund projects that are already completed nor reimburse expenses that have already been incurred.

Engagement, Evaluation, & Assets

We are interested in understanding the rationale behind your work. These questions will ask specific details about the activities funded by this grant and how your work connects to the community impact you hope to see.

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT*

Please describe how you are engaging the people most impacted by your program/organization as partners or co-creators in the work. Can you cite an example of a time you changed course based on this community engagement?

Community engagement can range from survey and focus group feedback to community members acting as co-creators and strategists in the design of a project. We look to see those most impacted by the work engaged as closely as possible. It is one thing to collect information. It is something else to change course based on an analysis of what has been collected and what the community says it needs.

Our program design is co-created with the individuals we serve. The demand for mechanical work came directly from participants in our Group Day program. In our agricultural program (funded by Bama Works 2024), we observed individuals who excelled when given mechanical tasks like fixing hose reels or assembling wheelbarrows, rather than planting. They requested more "fixing" work. We responded by piloting small engine repair, including fixing a donated chainsaw, purchasing 2 zero turn mowers through

Facebook Marketplace, and rehabilitating a 1960s-era Gavely walk-behind tractor, but quickly realized our dirt-floor barn was insufficient and created challenges keeping equipment safely raised.

We also engage the community through the "circular economy" model. Neighbors donate broken equipment, and our participants repair it. This creates a direct feedback loop: the community provides the "curriculum" (broken mowers), and our students return value (refurbished units).

External partners are integral to our design. We have consulted with Phil at VA Tractor and Pete at Gingerich Outdoor Power. These local business owners made recommendations for our shop design to ensure we are training students on industry-standard tools. Their feedback shaped our request for a rotary lift, ensuring our students learn skills that are genuinely transferable to local employers.

IMPACT*

What would success and/or progress look like over the next 12 months? How will you measure, evaluate, and then refine your work?

What specific, quantifiable benchmarks do you hope to reach and what indicators will let you know that you have reached them? What kind of long-term changes do you expect to see if this work continues? Will your work impact the broader community?

Success will be measured by facility completion and student outcomes.

Short-Term (12 Months):

- Infrastructure: Completion of the concrete floor and ventilation system by September 2026.

- Capacity: The shop will support 5-8 participants per week in vocational shifts.

- Synergy: The shop will successfully maintain the equipment used by the Agricultural program, reducing our external repair costs.

- Throughput: Participants will refurbish 20 pieces of equipment, diverting ~5,000 lbs of metal from landfills.

Long-Term (3-5 Years):

The primary long-term impact is economic independence. This lab serves as the training ground for our DBHDS-supported employment program. We aim to place 3-5 graduates annually into competitive employment. We will evaluate success using the Individual Support Plan (ISP) framework, tracking skill acquisition (e.g., "Student can independently change oil") and economic metrics (wages earned). This project creates a replicable model for "Green Vocational Training."

CAPACITY & PARTNERS*

Please describe why your organization is particularly well-positioned to do this work and carry out these goals at this time. Also describe any partners and their role in helping to achieve these goals.

Consider feasibility factors such as: time, costs, organizational capacity, ethics, your relationship and reputation with the population you will engage, any groundwork that has already been laid, etc

Autism Sanctuary is uniquely positioned to execute this project due to our rapid organizational maturity. In the last 2 years, we have transitioned to a Medicaid-licensed provider with a projected budget exceeding $1M. We have the administrative capacity to manage grant funds compliantly.

Our location, Edgefield Farm, provides the perfect "living laboratory." Unlike a classroom, our 85-acre property requires constant maintenance, providing a never-ending supply of "real work."

We are supported by a robust ecosystem. VA Tractor and Gingerich Outdoor Power serve as technical advisors. Quality Welding provides structural consultation. Operationally, we partner with Region Ten CSB for referrals, DBHDS for workplace vocational training revenue, and DARS providers for employment support. This is not a standalone project; it is the infrastructure component of a fully funded, Medicaid-reimbursable vocational program.

Financial Position

Ongoing Expenses*

If you will incur expenses beyond the scope of this grant (ex. a staff salary) for this program, what are your plans to meet those ongoing needs?

Please note any identified funding sources or opportunities you plan to pursue as well as any already-committed revenue streams.

The expenses covered by this grant are one-time capital improvements. Once installed, the ongoing costs to operate the vocational program (staff salaries, insurance) are covered by our operational budget.

Our primary revenue source is Medicaid reimbursement for "Workplace Assistance" services. As a licensed provider, we bill for the hours our staff spend training and supporting participants. This revenue stream covers facility maintenance and instructor salaries. Additionally, the program utilizes a social enterprise model where refurbished equipment is sold to the public, generating unrestricted income for consumable supplies.

Additional Budget Narrative

Is there anything in your budget attachments that you would like to explain further to the review committee(s)?

Autism Sanctuary stands at a convergence of opportunity. The operational funding is secured through Medicaid. The agricultural program (funded by your Fall 2024 grant) is thriving but needs mechanical support. The only impediment to launching this complementary vocational track is a 600-square-foot patch of dirt.

Matching*

If awarded, will this grant be counted towards an existing match from another funding source?

No

Additional Application Narrative

Is there anything else you would like the Community Foundation to know in order to better understand your work and your proposal?

We prepared a presentation sharing images of the property and community we serve. The file size exceeds the upload limit. You may view it online: https://www.dropbox.com/scl/fi/kf9ns7v27n0hxcy7jdqvl/Autism-Sanctuary-Overview.pdf?rlkey=phvoqop0an5ymsmp0rp5de988&dl=0

Sharing Permissions

The Community Foundation shares application submissions with its fundholder community. This is optional and with the permission of the organization only. By checking below, you agree to the following:

"I give permission for the Community Foundation staff to share this application with donors who might be interested in supporting the work outlined in this proposal."

Yes, the Community Foundation staff may share this application with donors.

Uploads

Allowed file types include PDF (preferred), Excel or Word. Please contact grants@cacfonline.org for any technical support.

Current Fiscal Year Operating Budget*

Current Fiscal Year Operating Budget including projected income and expenses. Typically, this is the annual budget approved by the board.

Organizational Budget 2026.pdf

Previous Fiscal Year Budget vs. Actuals or Profit and Loss Statement*

Previous Fiscal Year Operating Budget **including actual income and expenses**. Typically, this is the most recently-closed annual budget for the organization. **It shows the budgeted amounts and actual income and expenses**.

Autism Sanctuary Profit and Loss CY2025.pdf

Project Budget

Budget for Requested Funding (only for applications seeking support for a specific program)

Lab budget.pdf

Additional Supporting Documentation

Additional Supporting Documentation (like letters of support, brochure, 1-pager, photos, or anything else that tells the story).

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File Attachment Summary

Applicant File Uploads

- Organizational Budget 2026.pdf
- Autism Sanctuary Profit and Loss CY2025.pdf
- Lab budget.pdf

	FY25	FY26 Projected	YoY Change	Notes
Revenue				
Grants	$ 39,694.60	$ 75,000.00	189%	
Fundraising/Gifts/Bequeths	$ 73,900.35	$ 150,000.00	203%	
State of Virginia	$ 176,076.00	$ -	N/A	Vehicle grant for accessible van and BOC
Fee for Service				
Supported and In-home	$ 57,853.46	$ 200,000.00	346%	
Workplace Assistance	$ 5,185.00	$ 25,000.00	482%	
Group Day and Community Engagement	$ 301,510.42	$ 350,000.00	116%	
Sponsored Residential	$ 689,908.74	$ 1,000,000.00	145%	
Agricultural sales	$ 9,101.63	$ 15,000.00	165%	
Miscellaneous Income	$ 377.39	$ 500.00	132%	
	$ 1,353,607.59	$ 1,815,500.00	134%	
Funding uses/Expenses				
Personnel	$ 265,289.45	$ 450,000.00	170%	
Occupancy	$ 2,673.00	$ 6,000.00	224%	
Development/Fundraising	$ -	$ 30,000.00		
Other Operational Expenses	$ 50,871.00	$ 85,000.00	167%	
Agricultural Expenses	$ 15,610.55	$ 10,000.00	64%	
Supported Living staff	$ 30,000.00	$ 140,000.00	467%	
Sponsors (Residential Services)	$ 553,092.49	$ 825,000.00	149%	
Construction Costs	$ -	$ 400,000.00		Costs to construct agriculture activity barn
	$ 917,536.49	$ 1,946,000.00	$ 2.12	

Profit and Loss

Autism Sanctuary

Date Range: Jan 01, 2025 to Dec 31, 2025

Report Type: Accrual (Paid & Unpaid)

ACCOUNTS	Jan 01, 2025 to Dec 31, 2025
Income	
Direct Public Support – Corporate Contributions	$423.90
Direct Public Support – Grants	$39,694.60
Direct Public Support – Individual Contributions	$73,476.45
Lodging Income	$377.39
Market and direct sales	$4,149.52
Program Income - Supported and In-home	$57,853.46
Program Income - Workplace Assistance	$5,185.00
Program Income – Group Day and Community	$301,510.42
Program Income – Sponsored Residential	$689,908.74
Sales Discounts	-$42.50
Wholesale sales	$4,952.11
Total Income	**$1,177,489.09**
Total Cost of Goods Sold	**$0.00**
Gross Profit	**$1,177,489.09**
As a percentage of Total Income	**100.00%**

Operating Expenses	
Accounting Fees	$2,807.77
Administrative Expense	$6,142.54
Bank Fees	-$320.48
Cattle expenses	$15,610.55
Contract Services - Farm	$1,571.76
Contract Services - Interns	$2,350.00
Contract Services - Other	$40,219.38
Contract Services - Sponsors	$553,092.49
Contract Services - Supported	$30,000.00
Equipment purchase	$737.09
Farm Supplies	$6,248.69
Insurance - Workers Comprehensive	$2,670.00
Insurance – Property	$1,716.50
Legal Fees	$765.00
Marketing	$950.00
Meals & Entertainment	$898.70
Membership & Dues	$100.00
Merchant Account Fees	$86.75
Office Supplies	$662.18
Payroll – Employee Benefits	$35,796.42
Payroll – Employer's Share of Benefits	$16,957.92
Payroll – Salary & Wages	$186,923.65
Postage & Delivery	$17.49
Repairs & Maintenance	$2,269.93
Trash Service	$174.00

Operating Expenses	
Travel and Expenses	$1,619.25
Total Operating Expenses	**$910,067.58**

Net Profit	**$267,421.51**
As a percentage of Total Income	**22.71%**

Small Engine Repair Vocational Training Lab Budget

1. Concrete & Site Work	$	6,000
Slab, minimal grading, and drainage around the barn.		
2. Structural & Environmental	$	1,500
Insulation (targeted areas), exhaust fan/hood, basic electrical improvements for safe tool use.		
3. Work Bay & Equipment	$	1,500
Small rotary lift		
(If feasible) Scissor lift or at least a plan for mounting future upgrades		
4. Interior Build-Out	$	750
Shelving, workbenches, cabinets, tool racks		
5. Program Setup	$	250
Signage, safety gear (PPE), and minimal tool upgrades necessary for participants to work safely.		
	$	**10,000**